

1 Thessalonians, Part 2

1 Thessalonians 4-5 | Holy living and resurrection hope

SERIES QUESTION What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

BIG IDEA Because Christ will return and raise his people, believers pursue holiness, love, hope, and watchful faithfulness.

Follow the movement

PASSAGE	HOW RESURRECTION HOPE SHAPES LIFE
4:1–8	God calls believers to sanctification, sexual holiness, self-control, and honor.
4:9–12	Love grows “more and more”; quiet, responsible work supports a credible witness to outsiders.
4:13–18	Because Jesus died and rose, deceased believers will rise and share fully in Christ’s coming. The church grieves with hope.
5:1–11	The Day will arrive unexpectedly. Children of light stay awake through faith, love, hope, and mutual encouragement.
5:12–24	A waiting church respects, warns, encourages, helps, prays, tests, and trusts the faithful God to sanctify his people.

The gospel answer to death

THE CONCERN	PAUL’S ANSWER
Will believers who die before Christ returns be left behind?	No. Jesus died and rose; the dead in Christ will rise first, and all his people will be gathered together.
Should Christians grieve?	Yes—but not without hope. Death hurts, yet it does not have the final word.
Why does Paul teach this?	“Therefore encourage one another with these words” (4:18).

Look closer

CAUGHT UP — 4:17 The English word “rapture” comes through the Latin translation of this verb. The passage teaches a real gathering to Christ, but it does not by itself provide a complete end-times timetable.

THE DAY OF THE LORD — 5:2 This Old Testament expression points to God’s decisive intervention in judgment and salvation. Paul’s emphasis is readiness: live as children of the coming day.

Waiting for Christ is active

NOT THIS	BUT THIS
Date-setting and anxious speculation	Watchful living rooted in faith, love, and hope
Grief without hope	Honest grief strengthened by resurrection promise
Withdrawal from ordinary responsibilities	Holiness, growing love, responsible work, and public witness
Accepting or rejecting every spiritual claim automatically	Do not quench the Spirit; test everything; hold to what is good
Trying to sanctify ourselves by sheer effort	Obey seriously while trusting the faithful God who sanctifies

The Gospel Then and Now

CHURCH REALITY THEN Believers faced sexual pressure, grief, uncertainty about Christ's return, disruptive behavior, and the strains of congregational life.

CHURCH TEMPTATION NOW We can separate future hope from present holiness, chase prophetic timetables, or let disagreements about the end times divide Christ's church.

GOSPEL-SHAPED CHURCH Because Jesus died, rose, and will return, the church grieves with hope, lives in holiness and love, tests carefully, and encourages one another.

Discuss

1. How should Christ's return change the way we live today?
2. What is the difference between grief and grief without hope?
3. What does watchfulness look like without date-setting?
4. Why must a church both welcome the Spirit's work and test everything?
5. Where do we need the promise, "The one who calls you is faithful, and he will do it"?

For further study

ECO CONNECTION Essential Tenet III.C: covenant life in the church; III.E: living in obedience to the Word of God. ecopres.org/constitution/

READ MORE ONLINE BibleProject, Book of 1 Thessalonians Guide: bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-thessalonians/

CLASS RESOURCES & UPCOMING LESSONS

keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/



BEFORE NEXT WEEK START HERE: Read 2 Thessalonians 1 and 2:1–17. **CONTINUE IF POSSIBLE:** Read the entire three-chapter letter. Notice how Paul addresses persecution, confusion about the Day of the Lord, and disorderly living.